anarchy. People don’t feel secure, because everything that has made India great has either been or is being destroyed. The fear is real, because when Rahul Gandhi spoke about the injustices that women have particularly faced, an FIR was lodged against him soon after (suggesting a correlation). People feel like they do not matter, with the government conducting the nation’s affairs as if it’s a ceaseless, mind-numbing reality TV show. It is no coincidence that tens of millions of Indians, including Dalits, the Adivasi, Other Backward Classes, women, minorities, farmers, labourers, small traders, professionals and the youth, joined the Yatra. They came not just to protect India’s Constitution, but to protect that inalienable value that confers each of them with civic freedoms and rights—that of one person, one value. They were thus joining to safeguard their own agency and individuality.

Like Mahatma Gandhi once did with the Dandi Yatra, Bharat Jodo traversed through villages and towns, interacting with people from all walks of life, listening to their concerns and conjoining them for a larger struggle. Like Babasaheb Ambedkar’s Mahad Satyagraha, Bharat Jodo fought for the most voiceless despite overwhelming odds. This was not easy because of the constant security threat (which is not a small matter, given that two generations of the Gandhi family have paid the ultimate price while serving the nation). But Rahul Gandhi kept walking. In the countless public rallies, interactions with communities and dialogues with diverse groups, he bound India together by sheer force of will.

In the past decade, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has undemocratically tried to mould mass consciousness through its propaganda machinery. It has done so by deviously misusing the media, social media, popular culture and public institutions. The BJP government has used these to impose its longstanding agenda of one leader, one ideology and one party. It can claim (as it has) that it is its political prerogative to disseminate its own propaganda. But in doing so, it has methodically suppressed the legitimate concerns of millions of Indians—whether it is students, farmers, Dalits, the Adivasi, minorities, state governments or any person holding a different view than that of the BJP. This is why India has erupted with small and big protests across the nation.